

Is It a Person or a Computer? Tips for Little Kids and AI

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Young children hear **AI** helpers like Alexa and Siri at home. They may also see videos made by **AI** on YouTube. Experts say the years before age 8 are a good time to learn what **AI** is and what it is not.

Researcher Lauren Girouard said **preschoolers** can already learn from **technology**. Scientists are still learning how kids use **AI** at home.

Jennifer Katzenstein of Johns Hopkins All Children's Hospital said parents can explain, "That's the computer answering." Kids can also ask another adult, so they learn the difference between a person's answer and a computer's answer.

Dr. Jenny Radesky said little kids are "much more **magical thinkers**." Her son thought Siri was a real woman in California until he was 7. She said parents can remind kids that a machine has never felt sad and has no body.

The group Common Sense Media says children 5 and younger should not have **AI** toys.

Word Treasure

AI -- AI, or artificial intelligence, is computer technology that can answer questions and make things.

preschoolers -- Preschoolers are young kids, usually ages 3 to 5, who have not started kindergarten.

technology -- Technology means tools and machines, like phones and computers, that people make to do things.

magical thinkers -- Magical thinkers are people, often little kids, who believe pretend things can be real.

researcher -- A researcher is a person who studies something carefully to learn new facts.

Background you need

AI helpers like Alexa and Siri are computer programs that listen and answer out loud. Because they talk in friendly voices, little kids may think a real person is speaking. Experts say early childhood is an important time for learning how the world works.

Break it down

WHO: Young children, their parents and experts like Lauren Girouard and Dr. Jenny Radesky

WHAT: Experts shared tips to help little kids learn that AI is a computer, not a person

WHERE: At home, with AI helpers like Alexa and Siri

WHY: Little kids are magical thinkers and may think AI voices are real people

Why it matters

Knowing the difference between a person and a computer helps kids use AI helpers safely and wisely.

Test what you remember

1. Which AI helpers do young kids hear at home?
 - (A) Mickey and Minnie
 - (B) Mario and Luigi
 - (C) Elmo and Big Bird
 - (D) Alexa and Siri
2. Before what age do experts say is a good time to learn about AI?
 - (A) Age 2
 - (B) Age 15
 - (C) Age 20
 - (D) Age 8
3. What can parents say when a smart speaker answers?
 - (A) "It is magic."
 - (B) "Be quiet now."
 - (C) "That's the computer answering."
 - (D) "That's your friend talking."
4. What did Dr. Jenny Radesky's son think about Siri?
 - (A) That it was a real woman in California
 - (B) That it was a robot from space
 - (C) That it was his teacher
 - (D) That it was a dog
5. What can parents remind kids about a machine?
 - (A) It can eat food
 - (B) It has a family
 - (C) It has never felt sad and has no body
 - (D) It sleeps at night
6. What does Common Sense Media say about AI toys?
 - (A) They are only for babies
 - (B) Every child should have one
 - (C) They should be used at school
 - (D) Children 5 and younger should not have them

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: C 4: A 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. **Jennifer Katzenstein:** Parents can explain that the computer is answering and have kids ask another adult too.
2. **Dr. Jenny Radesky:** Parents can remind kids that a machine has never felt sad and has no body.
3. **Common Sense Media:** Children 5 and younger should not have AI toys.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):